Tell Your Father's Story Once and Get the Whole Situation on One Page

Four prompts to put recent events in order, see who is doing what, name the decision in front of you, and write one page you can hand to anyone who asks.

Where you are

Something happened with your father, a fall, a hospital stay, a call from a neighbor, and now several people need to understand the situation at once. You have texts, half-remembered phone calls, and a feeling that someone else is handling the important parts.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can explain in two minutes what changed, who is involved, and what decision comes next, and you know which pieces are still missing.

A one-page situation brief with four headings: What Happened, Who Is Involved and What They Do, The Decision in Front of Us, and What We Still Need to Find Out.

Before you start

- Whatever notes you have about what happened, in any form.
- Names of the people who have been involved this week.
- Any date or deadline someone mentioned, even if you're not sure it's firm. If you only have one of these, start anyway.

PROMPT 1

Put the last two weeks in order

WHY THIS MATTERS

When several things happen fast, the order gets lost, and the order matters. A nurse's comment on Tuesday means something different if the fall was on Monday.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Every note you have, in whatever shape it's in.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My father's situation changed recently and my notes are a mess: texts from my sister, things the nurse said on the phone, a voicemail from the discharge planner, and my own memory. Here they

> are:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES, TEXTS, AND ANYTHING ELSE]
>
> Put everything into one dated timeline, oldest first. Beside each entry, mark whether I saw it myself, someone told me, or I am not sure where it came from. Pull out any dates or deadlines anyone mentioned into a separate list. If two notes disagree, show both and say so. Do not add anything I didn't write.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A timeline you recognize, with the second-hand items clearly marked.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Check the dates you weren't sure of with the person who told you.

PROMPT 2

Find out who is actually doing what

WHY THIS MATTERS

In a hurry, families assume. Your brother thinks you called the pharmacy. You think he did. Your father's care is whatever the gaps allow.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A list of everyone involved and what you believe each person is handling.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everyone involved in my father's care this week and what I think each person is doing:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Turn this into a table with four columns: TASK, WHO I THINK IS DOING IT, HAVE I CONFIRMED THIS (yes, no, or unsure), and WHEN IT LAST HAPPENED AS FAR AS I KNOW. Then list the tasks where I wrote nothing about who is responsible, and the people I named who have no task next to them. Finally, tell me who seems to be the one everyone else calls for information. Do not decide whether any gap is dangerous; just show me where it is.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The tasks with 'unsure' beside them, and the one person whose phone is ringing most.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Make the confirming calls today. Two or three will do.

PROMPT 3

Name the decision in front of you

WHY THIS MATTERS

A crisis blurs together what is happening now, what someone has proposed, and what the family must actually decide. Separating them makes the next conversation shorter.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your timeline, your table, and anything anyone has suggested should change.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> This is where things stand with my father:
>
> [PASTE YOUR TIMELINE AND TABLE]
>
> And here is what different people have suggested should happen next:
>
> [PASTE THE SUGGESTIONS]
>
> Separate this into three sections: HOW THINGS ARE ARRANGED RIGHT NOW, WHAT HAS BEEN PROPOSED AND BY WHOM, and THE DECISION OUR FAMILY HAS TO MAKE NEXT, with any date attached to it. Under the decision, list the facts we would need before we could make it well, and mark each one as something we have, something we can find out ourselves, or something that needs a professional. Do not recommend which option we should pick.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

One clearly stated decision, not five, and the short list of facts it depends on.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Agree with the family that this is the decision, before anyone argues about the answer.

PROMPT 4

Write the page you can hand to anyone

WHY THIS MATTERS

The discharge planner, your aunt, the doctor's office, and your sister all want the same story. Writing it once saves you from telling it twenty times, and it keeps the story the same each time.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What the first three prompts gave you.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've gathered about my father's situation:
>
> [PASTE WHAT YOU GOT FROM PROMPTS 1, 2, AND 3]
>
> Write one page with four headings: WHAT HAPPENED, WHO IS INVOLVED AND WHAT THEY DO, THE DECISION IN FRONT OF US, and WHAT WE STILL NEED TO FIND OUT. Keep it in plain language a relative who has heard nothing could follow. Where I don't know something, write “not yet known” rather than guessing. Where two people told me different things, include both versions. At the bottom, add one line naming the family contact and a backup, which I will fill in.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page you'd be comfortable reading aloud to your father, if he asked.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Fill in the contact line and share the page with the family. Then take it to the next step below.

Your page is the start of the file.

The brief you just wrote covers what you already know. The care interview asks about the rest of your father's situation, area by area, and turns it into a Family Care Profile the family and a professional can work from.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›